agreement on Berlin while noting that “the measures undertaken so far are directed against the residents of East Berlin and East Germany and not against the Allied position in West Berlin or the access routes to West Berlin.”

The president’s sanguine view was not shared by the people of West Berlin. They felt that the construction of the wall was aimed against them and demanded American help. Once again, Kennedy was looking weak. Once again, he had to do something drastic without being irresponsible and raising tensions even further. Another request for military funding and calling in reservists would not do the trick. Kennedy rose to the challenge when the mayor of West Berlin, Willy Brandt, asked for the reinforcement of the American garrison. On August 20, one week after the sealing of West Berlin, 1,500 US troops marched on Kennedy’s orders toward the city along the only highway linking it with West Germany in order to reaffirm American access rights, reinforce the garrison, and reassure the West Berliners. Both Kennedy and Khrushchev hoped that the march would go off without a hitch and that there would be no accident. None took place.[25]

What the Berlin Wall really meant was anything but clear at the time. It did not result in an immediate conflict, but could it lead to a new one in the future? Khrushchev reached out to Kennedy in late September 1961, still arguing in favor of a peace treaty. Kennedy rejected the idea. “I do not see the need for a change in the situation of West Berlin, for today its people are free to choose their own way of life and their own guarantees of that freedom,” he wrote on October 17. He accepted the wall, but that was the limit of his flexibility. Khrushchev received Kennedy’s letter on October 19. Three days later, on October 21, speaking to the Twenty-Second Party Congress in Moscow, he removed the end-of-year deadline from his ultimatum threatening to sign a peace treaty with East Germany. Ulbricht, who had seen the wall as a stepping-stone to a future peace agreement with the Soviets, as well as to the establishment of his government’s sovereignty over East Berlin and access routes to West Berlin, was anything but pleased. He wrote to Khrushchev indicating his dissatisfaction with the Soviet leader’s declaration.[26]

If Khrushchev had difficulty controlling Ulbricht, Kennedy had his own rebel to deal with. This was General Lucius Clay. The successor to